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Uzbek Nationalism

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"Putin better occupy Uzbekistan and recreate the Soviet Union", my literature teacher Margarita Ivanovna declared. "There is no way something like that could happen", the 17-year-old me replied, as others sat silent. Her watery eyes glittered, her quivering lips were covered with foam, her face turned pale, and she breathed with menace. All of a sudden, Margarita Ivanovna started screaming, convulsing. She called me a "barbarous Mongolian". "If you hate Uzbekistan so much, you could return to your great Russia", I snapped. She stopped yelling and, turning in my direction, walked quickly up to me and started touching my belongings: literature notes, sketchbook, blue Android phone, my grey backpack. "GET OUT!" she shouted, "GET! OUT!" Margarita Ivanovna forcefully pushed me out of the classroom.

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The rapid occupation of territories of the Uzbek Khanates by the Russian Empire happened in 11 years. (Tashkent in 1865; Protectorates over Bukharan Emirate in 1868 & Khivan Khanate in 1873; Kokand Khanate was abolished in 1876, and the territories were directly joined into the Russian Turkestan)[1]. Though early Russian military outposts and settlements bordering the Kazakh steppe were established in the early 17th century, and continued being built in the 18th century[2] Uzbek Khanates didn't make any efforts for modernization. Uzbek Khanates had strict vertical power through Islam over the settled and semi-nomadic population of Central Asia, whereas nomadic Kazakhs didn't have any centralized power over themselves.[3]

Russia's colonization of the Caucasus began in the 16th century and escalated into a massive imperial expansion during the early 19th century. Since then, the Caucasus captured imaginations and was a place of inspiration for Russian romanticism (Pushkin, Lermontov, Bestuzhev-Marlinsky). In the late 19th century, Leo Tolstoy revisited the Caucasus in his novel Hadji-Murat by criticizing imperial occupation and the murders of indigenous people.

In marked contrast to the Caucasus, Central Asia didn't capture the Russian cultural imagination even after 50 years of imperial rule. I remember that only in Anna Karenina was Tashkent mentioned in the context of Vronsky's departure[4]. And in Nabokov's Gift, the whole Turkestan was mentioned, where the main character's father researched the butterflies in Tien Shan mountains[5].

Only after the creation of the Soviet Union do we start seeing cultural works centering Central Asia. In the film Tashkent, City of Bread, Turkestan was depicted as a land of plenty where hungry Russian peasants could take whatever they wanted.

In the film twelve-year-old Mishka Dodonov's family starves in his village in the Volga, so he decides to go to Tashkent. Bread is free; one can line their pockets with apricots; grapes are big there. It is a very Russian tale of muzhiks on the move.

Before leaving home, Stepan, a son of a *kulak* and White officer, tries to kill Mishka and his mom. But he doesn't kill them because the Cheka is near, and Stepan says to be grateful to Stalin. Mishka rides a train without a ticket. The train is full of Russians, even as they pass through the Kazakh steppe. We can see the young Kazakh girl, Saule. She's already joined Komsomol. She's going on a train to join the Red Guards to fight with counter-revolutionaries. On the train, we meet Stepan again, and Saule sacrifices herself to save Russians.[6]

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Modern Uzbek nationalism builds itself on Uzbek traditions, Islam, and Jadids. Through reading modern Uzbekistan's history textbooks, we can see the fact that Uzbekistan, as a supplier of cotton, is shown to be merely a "red colony", no better (and perhaps worse) than India or Egypt under British rule. Stalin's terrors are depicted as colonial policies. In this dilettante essay I will try to argue that the history of Central Asia cannot be seen through a binary or two-valued system of good Central Asians and bad Russians. I will try to break black or white syndrome.

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In the early 16th century, the oasis cities were conquered by Turko-Mongol dynasties tracing descent from an ancestor named Uzbek. Having destroyed the Timurid Empire and captured the settled population of Mavarannahr and settled in cities and towns, the Uzbeks had no desire for the hardships of settled life. Obviously, given that they were all Sunni Muslims, the Uzbeks were prohibited from making slaves of the Turkic inhabitants of Mavarannahr. Therefore, they looked for slaves beyond their own borders. Initially, the Uzbeks' appetite for slave labor had been satiated by a supply of Indian captives. Kafir Hindus were traded for Central Asian horses[7].

As even before the 16th-century Uzbek invasion, Timurids were actively engaged in the Indian slave trade. For instance, during Timur's late 14th-century sack of Delhi, several thousand skilled artisans were enslaved and taken to Samarkand. They used slaves for maintaining irrigation canals, working in brick factories, and in construction engineering.[8] Later, the supply of Hindu slaves dried up. Khorasan, which Uzbeks lost to the Safavids, had become the target of Uzbek raids. Muslim clergy of Central Asia, with Shams al-Din Herati, gave the fatwa by which Shia Muslims could be sold into

slavery just as kafirs. With this, the demand for Persian slaves only increased. Here, religion was used to sanctify economic gains through violence at the expense of Shia Muslims of Herat (Hazarrahs).[9]

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In 1820, Tsar Alexander I sent Baron von Meyendorf to the Bukharan Emirate. Meyendorf wrote back, "Every wealthy and respectable inhabitant of Bukhara owns slaves, mostly Persian." Slaves were used not only in agriculture, tending livestock, household services, and concubinage, but even in government offices. Meyendorf noted the whole administration was in the hands of the Qush-begi family and his slaves. There are other accounts of slaves serving as soldiers, officers, artillery, or every minor court official was a slave.[10]

The Central Asian slave trade remained active up to the Russian invasion. Jeff Eric's doctoral thesis at Harvard states that one million slaves were captured throughout the 18th and 19th centuries.[11]

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Apart from Central Asian slavery based on abductions and purchasing of Persian and Hazarrah population of Iran and Afghanistan, Uzbek aristocracy discriminated against its own settled population in towns and villages of Uzbek Khanates. From the 16th century conquest, the name Uzbek was applied to the ruling dynasties and their tribal followers, but not to the Turkic town- and village-dwellers of Mavarannahr. These turkic people not related to the Uzbek aristocracy were called Sarts.[12] Sart means "Merchant". Russians of the Tsarist regime used the word Sart in this meaning too, distinguishing Uzbek aristocracy and ordinary Sarts. The Soviet regime regarded Sart as pejorative and insulting and dropped it from the Russian vocabulary. The Jadids under Soviets extended the name Uzbek to include all the groups speaking related Turkic dialects.

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Jadidism was only one of the many movements that rejected the permissibility of customs and traditions through which Muslims had known Islam and been Muslims. [13] Jadids worked in Soviet organs and used Red Guards to achieve their goals in modernizing the nation. For instance, to destroy the Bukharan Khanate, the Young Bukharans sought the help of Bolsheviks. "In Young Bukharan manifestos, the emir appears not as the last surviving Muslim monarch in Central Asia, but as a corrupt, bloodthirsty despot."[14] The Young Bukharans included intellectuals like Sadriddin Ayni, Abdurauf Fitrat, Fayzulla Khodjaev, Osman Kocaoğlu, Musa Saidjanova, Akmal İkramov, etc.

Jadids had long seen traditionalist ulama as the biggest obstacle to the reform of society and Islam itself. [15] As local soviets helped to finance new-method schools and theater, they also helped the Jadids in striking at their opponents. In 1918, it was the old-city soviet in Tashkent that had outlawed the Ulamo Jamiyati and confiscated its assets. In January 1923, the same soviet banned Sufi figures from the streets and outlawed the public performance of zikr.[16]

In modern Uzbekistan history textbooks, the authors keep repeating that Jadidism was a Muslim movement. Their views on society didn't go against the religion, and they were just against corruption, superstition, and ignorance. However, some of the Jadids left Islam, not through Marxism, but through Islamicate knowledge.

For instance, a major figure of Jadidism was Fitrat. Fitrat used to write in Persian; he knew Arabic and studied in Stambul. He wrote several texts, not just criticising the ulama as many did, but also going against the Prophet himself. Fitrat wasn't a communist; he was shot in 1938.

In "Zayd and Zaynab," Fitrat retells the story of Muhammad's marriage to the divorced wife of his adoptive son Zayd, an episode mentioned in the Qur'an itself. Fitrat used this episode to put the focus on Muhammad's sexuality and on the nature of his prophethood. As if the story of Muhammad taking the wife of his son was not enough, Fitrat appended a note in his own name at the end: "Thus it was that God's best messenger, going on sixty, managed to separate a young woman from his own son through deceit and to take her for himself."[17]

Uzbek Nationalism, all else aside, claims that our ancestors fought the Russians to the death. In textbooks, they wrote, Soviet historiography claimed Basmachis to be terrorists, but they were a liberation movement of Jadids.

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The Basmachi rebellion was a Central Asian civil war, a war fought out amongst Central Asians. "Instead of being a heroic national resistance against outsiders, the Basmachi insurgency was a sign of deep divisions within Central Asian society."[18]

The Ulama or Uzbek aristocracy was a legitimate ruling class in settled part of Central Asia. The Russian Empire ruled over vast territories by not interfering with the religious practices in the region. They only abolished slavery, but other customs remained. It was true in the Caucasus and Turkestan regions. But Jadids saw this compromise as a way of blinding people, stopping them from true liberation and progress. So they wanted to destroy the Ulama class. And the Ulama class hated Urban Muslims. Basmachi consisted of sons of the ex-legitimate Uzbek ruling class of Imperial times; that's why they fought against Jadids and Bolsheviks.

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In 1917, the Provisional Government of Kerensky granted women the right to vote. The Ulama class in Turkestan resolutely opposed allowing women to vote. “For the Jadids, this was sheer madness; for all else aside, it meant disavowing half of the nation’s votes and thereby giving power to the Europeans.”[19]

In 1919, Fitrat wrote, “that the cause of the descent of the Muslim world into such dark ages are the tyrannical kings, our poets, who heaped false praise on them, and our eshons and mullas.’”[20]

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Uzbek nationhood was a prerevolutionary project of the national intelligentsia carried out in Soviet conditions. The USSR was a colonial empire. Nonetheless, the comparison with other colonial empires of the eighteenth, nineteenth, and twentieth centuries does not work.

“The Soviet Union’s cultural agenda - mass education in indigenous languages, fighting illiteracy, public health, political mobilization - had more in common with those of the mobilizational states of the interwar era, while its attempts to engineer society - land reform, women’s liberation, organization of marginal groups in society, reshaping the body social - have no parallels in the colonial empires of the era.”[21]

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But still I would not agree with Margarita Ivanovna and Dostoevsky. In Dostoevsky’s novel Demons, Shatov declares that “the only god-bearing people on earth, destined to regenerate and save the world in the name of a new God, and to whom are given the keys of life and of the new world... are the Russian people.”[22]

It is true that the institutions and a relative modernisation we have in post-Soviet Central Asia was brought by Russian Communists, but still this doesn’t give rights for Russians to claim our land. And Putin has no right over us, as Napoleon didn’t have rights to claim himself an emperor.

The famous storming of the Bastille on July 14, 1789 is considered to be a starting point of the French Revolution. Consequent Terror led by Robespierre and Saint-Just executed Louis XVI and Marie Antoinette. The Terror ended with executions of its own leaders, Robespierre and Saint-Just in July 1794. Then, there was a Directory with three consuls, among whom was Napoleon. The years between 1799 and the end of Napoleon’s reign 1815, brought a series of great military victories for France. They allowed Napoleon to impose his will, his reforms, and his legal code. Napoleonic Code abolished feudal privileges across occupied territories, established legal equality before the law. These reforms outlasted him, his legislation is foundational to civil law in France, Germany, Italy, Belgium, Switzerland, etc. [23]

But still I don't consider the last battle of Waterloo 1815 as the tragedy that ended Napoleonic Rule. I would highly agree with Victor Hugo that Waterloo was just the execution of another Robespierre. Victor Hugo in Les Miserables treated the battle as a cosmic turning point, that Napoleonic wars did change and define Europe, but there's no need for Napoleon in the 19th century.[24] Thus, following Hugo's way of thinking, I would assert that there's no need and place for the Russian Empire in the 21st century.

NOTES

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15. Khalid, Adeeb, Making Uzbekistan, Chapter 7, Muslim Anticlericalism, pp. 226
16. Khalid, Adeeb, Making Uzbekistan, Chapter 7, Islam between Reform and Revolution, pp. 220
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23. Daron Acemoglu, James Robinson, Why Nations Fail, Chapter 10, pp. 287-294
24. Victor Hugo, Les Miserables, Chapters 3-18, 385-437